would stay nonaligned and promised “strong friendship” and the commitment to “fulfill all our obligations.”[97]

While some in India had blamed the diversification strategy for leaving Delhi without friends during the war, most—in government and seemingly among the public—were not ready to jettison the strategy. Some argued that it had indeed worked. After the war, for example, Nehru stated his belief that because of the India-Soviet relationship, Moscow had exerted “some pressure” on Beijing for a ceasefire.[98] And “it is, we think, of the utmost importance that the Soviet Union maintains this attitude [of support to India] in the Sino-Indian conflict.… Even if there were no other valid reasons, our maintaining our policy of nonalignment is essential for this purpose.”[99] Policymakers felt vindicated when, in September 1963, Moscow made clear that it would not be obliged to stand by the Sino-Soviet treaty if China again attacked India.[100]

Contrary to Bowles and Chavan’s later contentions, India did not turn to the Soviet Union after it became clear that a more comprehensive defense agreement with the US would fall through in 1963.[101] Its military relationship with the Soviet Union commenced before and continued through discussions with the US and UK.[102] Moscow had held up delivery of MiGs during the war. But Khrushchev had indicated in late November 1962 that Moscow would resume supply.[103] The Soviet Union delivered a few MiGs in spring 1963 with more to come later. Meanwhile, India moved ahead with plans to manufacture the planes domestically and that fall also announced that the two countries had agreed to build India’s domestic capacity to manufacture missiles and radar equipment, among other defense deals. Moscow provided $130 million in military assistance between October 1962 and May 1964 according to some reports, and even more subsequently.[104]

Even beyond the defense realm, India did not want to put all its eggs in the Western basket. It helped to have multiple benefactors—a lesson brought home even on the economic front after it became evident that, despite the Kennedy administration’s support, congressional opposition meant the US could not fund the construction of a public sector steel mill at Bokaro. Subsequently, Moscow financed the mill instead.[105]

There was also a domestic reason for maintaining the Soviet option: nonalignment had staying power. It continued to be “a very real concept”